

Zoo Lions Act More Like Wild Lions With Big Meals

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Wild lions do not eat at the same time every day. Sometimes they have a huge meal, and then they go days without food. Scientists in Australia wanted to see what happens when zoo lions eat that way too.

Researchers from Adelaide University worked with Monarto **Safari Park** in South Australia. They watched three adult male African lions. Every nine days, the lions got a whole animal to eat instead of just pieces of meat.

Eight special cameras filmed the lions day and night for three months. On big-meal days, the lions spent almost three times as long eating. They pulled and tore at their food, just like wild lions.

After eating, the lions rested for a long time. Then, day by day, they became more **active** again. Scientists said this **pattern** looked a lot like how wild lions live.

"Wild lions don't eat at the same time every day," said researcher Lesia Hryhorenko.

Word Treasure

Safari Park -- A large park where wild animals live in big open spaces.

Researchers -- People who study something carefully to learn new facts.

pattern -- Something that happens again and again in the same way.

active -- Moving around and doing things.

Background you need

Wild lions hunt for food, so they sometimes eat a big meal and then go days without eating. Zoos and safari parks try to help animals act the way they would in the wild.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists from Adelaide University and Monarto Safari Park

WHAT: They gave three zoo lions a whole animal to eat every nine days

WHERE: Monarto Safari Park in South Australia

WHY: To see if eating like wild lions helps zoo lions act more naturally

Why it matters

It helps zoos keep animals happier and healthier, so kids can see lions acting more like they do in the wild.

Test what you remember

1. How often did the lions get a whole animal to eat?
 - ☐ (A) Once a year
 - ☐ (B) Every day
 - ☐ (C) Every nine days
 - ☐ (D) Every hour
2. How many lions did the scientists watch?
 - ☐ (A) Twenty
 - ☐ (B) Three
 - ☐ (C) Ten
 - ☐ (D) One
3. How long did the cameras film the lions?
 - ☐ (A) One week
 - ☐ (B) One day
 - ☐ (C) Three months
 - ☐ (D) Five years
4. How much longer did the lions eat on big-meal days?
 - ☐ (A) Half as long
 - ☐ (B) Almost three times as long
 - ☐ (C) The same amount
 - ☐ (D) Ten minutes longer
5. What did the lions do after eating?
 - ☐ (A) Roared all night
 - ☐ (B) Went to sleep for a month
 - ☐ (C) Rested for a long time
 - ☐ (D) Ran in circles
6. Which country was the study in?
 - ☐ (A) India
 - ☐ (B) Canada
 - ☐ (C) Australia
 - ☐ (D) Kenya

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: C 4: B 5: C 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Researcher Lesia Hryhorenko: Says wild lions don't eat at the same time every day.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):